

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Consulting English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For management consultants, strategy consultants, implementation consultants, analysts, engagement managers, client partners, internal consultants, and advisory teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Client Discovery and Problem Definition

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Hypotheses and Issue Trees

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

03 Data Requests and Client Burden

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

04 Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

05 Scope Management and Change Requests

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

06 Difficult Client Feedback

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

07 Implementation and Change Management

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

08 Steering Committees and Final Readouts

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Client Discovery and Problem Definition

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A client requests a benchmarking study but actually needs to decide whether to centralize a service.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: discovery, problem statement, decision question, stakeholder.

Model response

What decision will the benchmark help you make? If the question is centralization, we should examine the criteria and constraints first, then decide which external comparisons would be useful.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Benchmarking for which decision? - The lesson's client asks for benchmarking but needs to decide whether to centralize a service.
2. A dashboard request conceals a handover problem - Separate fictional case: a client asks for a new dashboard because orders repeatedly wait between sales and operations; the reason for the waiting is unknown.

3. Cost reduction or more reliable delivery? - Separate fictional case: a sponsor asks for efficiency improvements, while a project brief mentions both lower cost and more reliable delivery without ranking them.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A survey request with no decision owner

A fictional client requests an employee survey about office space, but has not identified whether the decision concerns desk allocation, attendance arrangements, or a lease. No decision owner is named. Hold a discovery call.

Role A: You are the consultant. Clarify the decision and its owner before discussing survey questions.

Role B: You are the client coordinator. Acknowledge the missing scope and identify whom you must consult.

Possible opening: Could you clarify which office-space decision this survey needs to support?

Success checks

- Separate the requested research method from the decision question.
- Keep the decision scope and owner explicitly unresolved.
- Agree the clarification needed before designing the research.

Add a complication: The coordinator wants to send a survey immediately to show progress.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Hypotheses and Issue Trees

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A team believes customer churn is caused by price but has not examined service experience or competitor changes.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: hypothesis, issue tree, workstream, evidence plan.

Model response

Price is one hypothesis, not an established explanation. I'll structure the work around the main alternatives and identify the evidence that would support or weaken each one.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. B - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. A - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. Price is a hypothesis, not the whole issue tree - The lesson's team attributes churn to price without examining service experience or competitor changes.
2. Late deliveries and a recent staffing change - Separate fictional case: delivery delays rose after a staffing change; order mix and supplier performance have not been examined.

3. One interview does not close a branch - Separate fictional case: one manager says customer onboarding delays never involve approvals; the team has not reviewed approval records or other interviews.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A branch with no possible disproof

A fictional team's hypothesis says customers leave because they dislike something. It does not identify a specific factor or evidence that could contradict it. Discuss how to make the hypothesis testable without inventing the cause.

Role A: You are the workstream lead. Ask for a specific proposed explanation and an evidence test.

Role B: You are the analyst. Refine the question while keeping alternative explanations open.

Possible opening: This hypothesis is too broad to test; which specific factor do we think may affect departures?

Success checks

- Distinguish a broad label from a testable explanation.
- Ask what evidence could support or weaken the hypothesis.
- Agree a focused evidence question without declaring a cause.

Add a complication: A colleague says any negative customer comment proves the hypothesis.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Data Requests and Client Burden

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A client receives a 40-item data request with one deadline. Only six items are needed for the first analysis.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: data request, confidentiality, owner, deadline.

Model response

Could we prioritize the six items needed for the first analysis and agree on their owners? I'll explain their purpose and propose later dates for the remaining requests to reduce unnecessary burden.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. A - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Six items first, not forty at once - Separate fictional extension of the lesson: a forty-item request is due Friday. The first analysis needs January-March order dates, completion dates, service types, status codes, team identifiers, and a field dictionary to compare turnaround by service. Other items can be deferred by agreement.

2. A sample extract before a large pull - Separate fictional case: a consultant needs two years of tickets for a resolution-time study. First, ten synthetic examples representing January 2026 are requested with ticket ID, opened time, resolved time, status code, and a code dictionary. This sample will check structure and meaning, not measure performance.

3. An unavailable field should not become a guess - Separate fictional case: a client can provide monthly totals but cannot currently export transaction-level timestamps requested for a cycle-time analysis.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A data owner is on leave

A fictional project's requested staffing extract belongs to an analyst who is on leave. No substitute owner or delivery date is confirmed. The first workshop can use an existing aggregate report, but its limitations must be explained. Agree a proportionate request.

Role A: You are the consultant. Ask for an authorized substitute or realistic availability check.

Role B: You are the client coordinator. Offer the aggregate report without claiming it replaces all requested detail.

Possible opening: Could you help identify an authorized owner for the extract, or confirm when the original owner can respond?

Success checks

- Request an appropriate owner without bypassing access arrangements.
- Explain what the aggregate report can and cannot support.
- Agree a realistic follow-up rather than invent a delivery commitment.

Add a complication: The consultant's colleague wants to pressure an unrelated employee to access the data.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A presentation has twelve charts and no clear recommendation. The audience must decide whether to pilot a new process.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: storyline, so what, recommendation, decision ask.

Model response

I'll lead with the pilot recommendation and the decision required, then use the strongest evidence and its limitations to support it. The remaining charts can answer follow-up questions.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. B - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Twelve charts and no decision ask - The lesson's presentation contains twelve charts but no clear recommendation; executives must decide whether to pilot a new process.
2. A finding is not yet a recommendation - Separate fictional case: a process study finds duplicate entry in two systems, but implementation costs and system constraints have not been assessed.

3. A headline that hides the tradeoff - Separate fictional case: two service options are being compared; A has a shorter stated rollout and B a lower quoted setup fee, while recurring costs remain unreviewed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An appendix becomes the opening

A fictional readout opens with ten minutes of method detail, leaving no time to discuss a limited pilot. A measured trial of ten handovers at one branch reduced median handover time from twelve minutes to nine; no other branch or live rollout has been tested. Discuss a clearer spoken order using this finding and its limited scope.

Role A: You are the engagement lead. Ask for the decision question, central finding, and main limitation first.

Role B: You are the analyst. Explain where the method detail can support questions rather than obscure the decision.

Possible opening: Let's begin with the pilot decision and the main finding, then use the method detail to support questions.

Success checks

- Explain the difference between sequencing evidence and concealing it.
- Keep the main limitation in the opening summary.
- Agree a clear storyline leading to the decision ask.

Add a complication: The analyst believes moving detail later means hiding it.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Scope Management and Change Requests

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A client requests a second market study halfway through an engagement. The existing schedule covers only the original market.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: scope, change request, tradeoff, statement of work.

Model response

We can assess the additional market as a scope change. Would you prefer to extend the schedule, add resources, or reprioritize the original work? I'll prepare the implications for discussion.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 · Conversations

1. A second market changes the engagement - The lesson's client requests a second market study midway through an engagement scoped and scheduled for one market.
2. An extra workshop without extra preparation time - Separate fictional case: a consulting engagement includes one leadership workshop; the client asks for a separate frontline workshop before the same readout, with no

additional capacity confirmed.

3. Translation for a new audience - Separate fictional case: a final report is scoped in English; the client requests a second-language presentation, but translation review and presenter availability are unassessed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A requested update after final handover

A fictional engagement has handed over its final analysis. The client now requests monthly refreshes, which were not included in the statement of work. Data access and refresh effort are unknown. Discuss a bounded follow-on option.

Role A: You are the engagement manager. Clarify frequency and purpose, then propose an assessment of the additional service.

Role B: You are the client sponsor. Discuss whether one later update could meet the immediate need.

Possible opening: Monthly refreshes would be additional work; could we clarify the decision each update needs to support?

Success checks

- Separate the completed engagement from proposed ongoing work.
- Offer a specific alternative with conditions.
- Avoid committing cost, timing, or access before assessment and agreement.

Add a complication: The sponsor assumes final handover includes indefinite ongoing support.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Difficult Client Feedback

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A client says a recommendation ignores a staffing constraint that the team missed in discovery.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: assumption, implementation constraint, stakeholder buy-in, iteration.

Model response

You're right that the recommendation does not account for that staffing constraint. Let's confirm its effect and revise the options. I'll make the changed assumption explicit in the next version.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. A - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. C - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 · Conversations

1. The staffing constraint we missed - The lesson's client says the recommendation overlooks a staffing constraint missed during discovery.
2. A recommendation sounded like a decision - Separate fictional case: a consulting presentation called a proposed role change the new operating arrangement; the client has not approved it.

3. An interview summary omitted the exception - Separate fictional case: a client's interview described a standard approval route and an exception for urgent repairs; the consulting summary included only the standard route.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An unavailable system was assumed available

A fictional recommendation assumes the client can use a reporting tool, but the client says access has not been approved. The analysis team never checked this assumption. Practice acknowledging the omission and planning a revised feasibility discussion.

Role A: You are the consulting lead. Own the unchecked assumption and explain what must change in the recommendation's status.

Role B: You are the client project manager. Ask for alternatives without committing to an unreviewed tool purchase.

Possible opening: We assumed access to the reporting tool without confirming it, so the current recommendation needs reassessment.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the specific unchecked assumption.
- Avoid making the client responsible for validating an unsupported recommendation after the fact.
- Agree a revised feasibility review with remaining unknowns explicit.

Add a complication: A consultant suggests the client simply buy access to preserve the original recommendation.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Implementation and Change Management

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

CASE

Managers are expected to adopt a new process but have not received training or time to practice.

Teach this move

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Vocabulary to check: operating model, change management, adoption, decision rights.

Model response

The rollout asks managers to change their work without enough preparation. Could we add role-specific training and a short practice period, then check where adoption is difficult?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Second-round challenge

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Language-check answers

1. C - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date. The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.
2. B - What is making this part of the task difficult? An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

05 • Conversations

1. Adoption needs practice, not just an announcement - The lesson's managers are expected to adopt a new process without training or practice time.

2. A manager keeps using the old approval route - Separate fictional case: in a practice session, a manager routes a request through the old approval sequence; the new decision-rights guide is available but has not been explained.

3. A change champion answers every question - Separate fictional case: during a new-process workshop, the change champion answers every case question before the other managers can respond. The coach gives feedback directly between practice rounds.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A checklist completed from memory

In a fictional practice session, a manager marks every new-process step complete without consulting the case evidence. Two steps have no supporting information. Give specific coaching feedback and agree another practice round.

Role A: You are the implementation coach. Describe the unsupported completion marks and their effect on process reliability.

Role B: You are the client manager who completed the checklist. Explain your approach, respond to the evidence gap, and agree how you will check each step in another practice round.

Possible opening: Two steps were marked complete without supporting information, so the checklist doesn't yet demonstrate correct process use.

Success checks

- Distinguish form completion from correct process use.
- Give and respond to behavior-specific feedback without guessing motives.
- Agree a practical evidence-based rehearsal and follow-up check.

Add a complication: The manager says completing the form quickly proves adoption.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Steering Committees and Final Readouts

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

A steering group agrees on the problem but is split between two options. The presentation time is almost over.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: steering committee, option set, risk, next step.

Model response

Let's pause the slides and compare the two options against the agreed criteria. Then we can record the decision, or the precise unresolved question and who will resolve it by when.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. B - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. A - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 · Conversations

1. The steering group has not selected an option - Separate fictional extension of the lesson: the steering group agrees that service handovers need improvement but is split between a one-branch pilot and a full rollout. Operations worries about untested training; the sponsor worries that a pilot delays wider benefits. Decision authority is unconfirmed and two minutes remain.
2. The absent operations voice - Separate fictional case: a steering committee discusses a proposed rollout while the operations representative is absent; operational resource requirements have not been confirmed.
3. A risk discussion needs a decision owner - Separate fictional case: a final readout presents a pilot with an unresolved supplier dependency; attendees discuss the risk but nobody identifies who can accept it.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A vote is suggested without an agreed process

A fictional steering discussion is divided between a small pilot and a wider rollout. A participant suggests an immediate show of hands, but the committee's decision method has not been confirmed. Facilitate a clear next process step.

Role A: You are the facilitator. Summarize both options and ask how the decision should be made.

Role B: You are the client sponsor. Accept responsibility for confirming the committee's decision process.

Possible opening: Before using a show of hands, could we confirm how this committee is authorized to decide?

Success checks

- Distinguish expressed support from a valid recorded decision.
- Preserve both options and the main unresolved concern.
- Assign confirmation of the decision process before claiming approval.

Add a complication: A participant interprets the louder support for rollout as formal approval.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Consulting English

Professional audience: management consultants, strategy consultants, implementation consultants, analysts, engagement managers, client partners, internal consultants, and advisory teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Client Discovery and Problem Definition

Original fictional case: A client requests a benchmarking study but actually needs to decide whether to centralize a service.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: discovery: The process of learning needs or facts; in litigation, formal exchange of relevant information. / problem statement: A clear description of the issue to be addressed and why it matters. / decision question: The specific choice or issue that an analysis needs to help resolve. / stakeholder: Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What decision will the benchmark help you make? If the question is centralization, we should examine the criteria and constraints first, then decide which external comparisons would be useful.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Consulting English

Professional audience: management consultants, strategy consultants, implementation consultants, analysts, engagement managers, client partners, internal consultants, and advisory teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Client Discovery and Problem Definition

Original fictional case: A client requests a benchmarking study but actually needs to decide whether to centralize a service.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level